

Project Profile: Goldmine Hollow at Hunter's Cabin

Case Study B: Wild Trout Tributary Restoration & Private Landowner Showcase

Location: Hunter's Cabin, Goldmine Hollow (tributary to Noontootla Creek), Fannin County, North Georgia

Receiving Stream: Noontootla Creek (State-Designated Wild Trout Stream)

Project Sponsor: Blue Ridge Stream Restoration & Mitigation LLC

1. Project Vision & Objectives

Noontootla Creek is legendary—widely recognized as one of the premier, highly protected wild trout streams in the Southeast, boasting self-sustaining populations of stream-born Rainbow and Brown trout. **Goldmine Hollow** is a critical coldwater tributary that feeds directly into Noontootla Creek at **Hunter's Cabin** (near Newport Road and Noontootla Ridge Court).

This project serves as Hunter's **Premium Private Landowner Showcase**:

1. **Sediment & Siltation Control:** Stop sediment runoff from Goldmine Hollow's steep slopes and access roads (like Peter Knob Road) from entering Noontootla Creek, protecting critical downstream wild trout spawning beds.
 2. **Tributary Step-Pool Restoration:** Reconstruct the steep geomorphic step-pools of the hollow's stream using native wood and stone, creating a sanctuary for juvenile wild brook and rainbow trout.
 3. **High-End Marketing Asset:** Use Hunter's own cabin and restored stream as a "living showroom" to pitch high-end design-build services to wealthy private landowners who own estates along premium trout waters like the Toccoa, Cartecay, and Soque rivers.
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2. Pre-Restoration Baseline (The Problem)

Goldmine Hollow, while pristine in its thermal regime (highly shaded and cold), suffers from physical geomorphic degradation:

- **Sediment Loading (Siltation):** Severe erosion from unpaved mountain access roads (such as Peter Knob Road and Newport Road) washes highly abrasive sandy-clay sediment into the hollow during heavy rains. This sediment settles at the confluence, smothering the clean cobble and gravel beds of Noontootla Creek.
 - **Debris Scouring & Headcutting:** High-velocity stormwater flows down the steep hollow have scoured out the natural plunge-pools, causing a "headcut" (vertical channel erosion) that threatens the stability of the cabin's stream crossings.
 - **Buffer Degradation:** Historic clearing close to the cabin has removed hemlocks and rhododendrons, exposing portions of the small creek to sunlight and increasing bank vulnerability.
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2. **The Fluvial Walkthrough:**

- Hunter conducts a guided walk along the restored Goldmine Hollow reach, showing exactly how natural logs, root wads, and stones stabilized the channel, cleared the water, and built robust trout holding pools without resorting to ugly concrete or rip-rap.

3. **The High-Margin Pitch:**

- This physical, highly visual showcase makes it incredibly easy to close direct design-build consulting contracts (averaging **\$50 to \$120+ per linear foot**) with wealthy landowners who want to restore streams on their own private estates.
- A single 1,000-foot private estate restoration generates **\$50,000 to \$100,000 in high-margin cash flow** with minimal regulatory permitting hurdles (permitted rapidly under general state maintenance and NWP 27).